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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1947, 1948, 1950

Coverage Date: 1945-1951

Place Coverage

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S)

CASE X: THE CHILD'S RIGHT TO CHOOSE HIS RESIDENCE

Mother and Children. The mother's rights and duties in her children are assimilated to those of the *basimukowa*. As their link with the matrilineal group she is given more formal honour than the father. In speaking of her, her children use the polite plural and the word for 'mother' is usually given in the plural form ' *Bamama*'. The father is addressed and spoken of in the singular, a form used among intimates and equals.

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From their mother, children derive their clan affiliation and their set of clan joking-partners. From her they also take their membership in the group which regulates inheritance and which was formerly the vengeance unit and the unit within which mutual responsibility operated. Through her and her kin, they receive the second of the 'ancestral' names given them in infancy and with it is associated a guardian spirit from the maternal line. Through her they gain their affiliation to the ancestral spirits whom they may approach directly.

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Social Placement

Most of the incidents of their lives show a balancing between the claims of the father's line and those of the mother's. But whereas the paternal claims are largely focused in the father himself, the rights and obligations of the maternal line are diffused very widely and lie not against a specific person but against the group as a whole, or against a general kinship category within it. Many of them are vested in the males of the group, and more particularly in the generation of the mother's brothers.

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The status of the mother is therefore much more personal than that of the father, without the same clear definition of a cultural norm. At the same time it is even more profoundly affected by the residence of the child and whether or not it grows up in its mother's household. It is only then that the mother speaks with  238 much authority later on in the affairs of her children. Otherwise this authority is likely to fall to the woman who has reared them.

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